LIFE ON BOARD

DISCIPLINE AND PUNISHMENT

A SHIP IS AN ENVIRONMENT in which problems of order and discipline are naturally acute. Men are crammed together for long periods of time, in boredom, danger, and discomfort. The lower orders always outnumber the officers, who are poorly placed to call for help in case of trouble. Crews also need to be drilled to work together as a tight-knit team in case of combat or to face crises such as storms at sea. The danger of their situation made most sailors favor good discipline, which would contribute to their survival.



INSPECTION The armed services take appearance very seriously as a reflection of personal discipline. These American sailors are waiting to have their gear inspected.



BEATING TO QUARTERS Drums, such as this 18th-century British example, were historically used to "beat to quarters," preparing the men for action. Sailors were exptected to clear the main gun deck and prime the cannons in preparation for battle.

STICKING TOGETHER

At best a ship's crew became its captain's bonded followers—a self-sufficient band owing allegiance primarily to one another and to their leader. Divisions between officers and men, normally rigid in class terms, were often less sharp in practice once at sea, simply because crew were so clearly all in it together. But a badly run ship with a sadistic captain was a hell-hole in any age. Naval warfare is studded with stories of desertion and mutiny—the latter often a systematic, almost formalized response to bad practice by a captain or officers, or to perceived breaches of customary law. Yet even in a good ship, where officers and men practiced mutual respect, there was a need for punishment to enforce discipline.

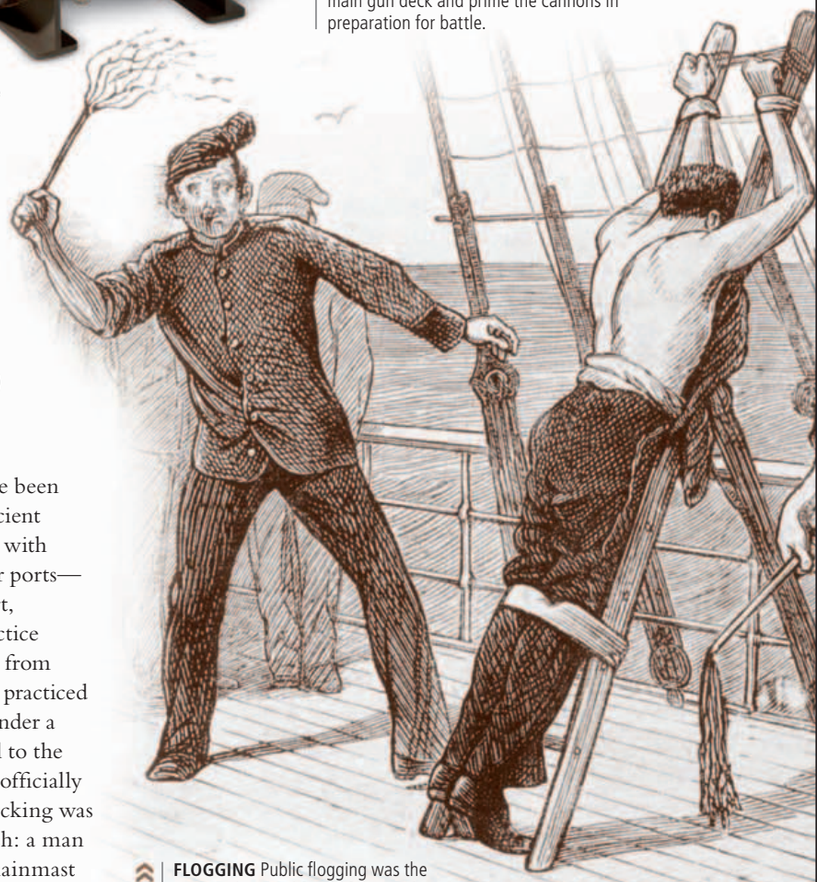
> *It is (the captain's) indispensable duty to see that the poor seaman be not wronged of his due, nor the service carried on by noise, stripes or blows.*
>
> **CAPT. CHRISTOPHER O'BRIEN,** Advice on Sea-Discipline & from a Father to his Son in Naval Tactics



LEG IRONS Also known as bilboes, these were fixed to the deck, and could be used either for punishment or to hold a man awaiting trial. The prisoner, who was locked in for several days, was fed on bread and water.

PECULIAR PRACTICES

Some ingeniously cruel punishments have been unique to navies. At the time of the Ancient Greek galleys, a malefactor might be lashed with his head sticking out of one of the lower oar ports—an uncomfortable public humiliation in port, but torture if at sea. Keel-hauling was a practice particularly associated with the Dutch navy from the 16th century, although also occasionally practiced by others. A man was tied to a rope slung under a ship and dragged from one side of the vessel to the other under the hull. Keel-hauling was not officially abolished in the Dutch navy until 1853. Ducking was a punishment much practiced by the French: a man was tied to a rope attached to one of the mainmast cross-trees and dropped into the sea, then heaved up again to repeat the exercise. There is little evidence to suggest "walking the plank" occurred.



FLOGGING Public flogging was the most widespread form of corporal punishment for breaches of naval code, with the number of lashes dependent on the severity of the crime.